

Paul Schöpfer

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Profile

Applied microeconomist working on the economics of education and development. Four years of experience designing, implementing, and analyzing randomized controlled trials and quasi-experimental evaluations across Sub-Saharan Africa and Eastern Europe. I combine rigorous causal analysis with hands-on project leadership, coordinating governments, NGOs, universities, and survey teams, and communicating findings clearly to academic, policy, and practitioner audiences.

Education

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| 11/2024–present | PhD in Development Economics (expected December 2026), Wageningen University & Research, Netherlands
Thesis title <i>Enhancing Life Outcomes: The Interplay of Holistic Skills, Preschool Education, and Technology of Instruction</i>
Supervisors Dr. Joost de Laat, Dr. Esther Gehrke, Dr. Thomas van Huizen
Dissertation research conducted since 07/2022 through my Junior Researcher position at Utrecht University, prior to formal PhD enrollment. |
| 08/2021–07/2022 | MSc in Economic Policy , Utrecht University, Netherlands |
| 10/2016–02/2021 | BSc in Economics , University of Vienna, Austria |

Professional Experience

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| 07/2022–present | Junior Researcher , Utrecht University School of Economics, Netherlands <ul style="list-style-type: none">Designed and conducted randomized controlled trials (RCTs) and quasi-experimental evaluations in the economics of education, in The Gambia, Kenya, and Nigeria.Analyzed experimental, survey, and administrative data (Stata, R), including replication and re-analysis of prior experimental results and heterogeneous treatment effect analyses.Developed sampling strategies and measurement instruments (surveys, indices, reliability and validity checks) and conducted power calculations for study design and research proposals.Managed field research across up to five countries in parallel, coordinating ministries, NGOs, universities, and survey firms, including enumerator training and supervision of data collection.Led design-based research pilots on garden-based education and foundational literacy and numeracy in Kenya and Malawi as principal investigator, with Edukans and local university partners.Presented research findings to policymakers, including the Gambian Ministry of Basic and Secondary Education and the Vice President of The Gambia, and advised on options for national scaling.Co-authored research proposals and concept notes for funders including J-PAL and the Finnish National Agency for Education, covering research design, power calculations, and budgets.External reviewer for NIERA (Network of Impact Evaluation Researchers in Africa), conducting structured reviews of impact evaluation proposals and inception reports.Organized international knowledge-exchange workshops with academics, policymakers, and practitioners in Utrecht and Nairobi. |
| 07/2019–06/2021 | Intern , Austrian Financial Market Supervision, Vienna, Austria
Drafted press releases, briefing notes, and external communications for senior management. |
| 08–12/2018 | Executive Secretary , Federal Chancellery of the Republic of Austria, Vienna, Austria
Coordinated high-level meetings during Austria's EU Council presidency. |

Manuscripts

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| 2026 | Does Extra Exam Practice Raise Test Scores? Experimental Evidence from Kenya and Nigeria
with Guthrie Gray-Lobe, Ronak Jain, Michael Kremer, Joost de Laat, and Becky Scurlock. Draft.
Two cluster-randomized trials on frequent testing in 245 schools (3,700+ students), using administrative test-score records and national leaving-exam data. |
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2026	Strengthening Student Outcomes Through Active Learning Methods. Experimental Evidence from The Gambia with Joost de Laat, Thomas van Huizen, Hamidou Jawara, and Tomohisa Miyamoto. Draft. RCT of a national competency-based curriculum reform and teacher training in 90 primary schools (2,100+ students), implemented with the Ministry of Basic and Secondary Education.
2026	Parental Beliefs and Home Investment. Evidence from Bulgaria with Joost de Laat, Esther Gehrke, and Thomas van Huizen. Draft. Survey of 1,000 parent–child pairs across 121 communities with a vignette-based belief elicitation, separating beliefs about skill production from beliefs about returns to skills.

Publications and Policy Reports

2024	Heller Crespo, R., van der Harst, M., Schöpfer, P., et al. (2024). Integrating Whole Child Development into Teacher Training. <i>NORRAG</i> . https://resources.norrag.org/resource/view/832/461
2024	Schöpfer, P., van der Harst, M., et al. (2024). Integrating Measurement into Education Systems. <i>NORRAG</i> . https://resources.norrag.org/resource/view/832/461

Editorial Roles

2025	Guest Editor, Special Issue “ <i>International Community-Engaged Learning (ICEL)</i> ”, <i>Journal of Higher Education Outreach and Engagement</i> , Vol. 29, Issue 2. https://openjournals.libs.uga.edu/jheoe/article/view/4371/3541
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Teaching Experience

2024–2026	Lecturer , Economics of Global Challenges, Utrecht University Led lectures, tutorials, and the community-engaged learning component with partners in southern Kenya (academic years 2024/2025 and 2025/2026).
2024–2025	Co-coordinator , Tackling Real-World Problems through Interdisciplinary Collaboration (TIC), Utrecht University Designed and managed an interdisciplinary, project-based course with societal partners including Commonland, RIVM, Triodos Bank, and Stichting Vluchteling.
2023–2024	Course Instructor , Thematic Interdisciplinary Challenge (TIC), Utrecht University Taught and supervised student teams in a project-based course on societal challenges.
2025	Guest Lecturer , Youth, Education and Society Master’s Program, Utrecht University Lecture on monitoring and evaluation in education programs, with a focus on measuring holistic and non-cognitive skills.

Skills

Methods	RCT design and implementation, quasi-experimental methods, power calculations, survey and index construction, reliability and validity testing, design-based research
Data	Stata, R, LaTeX, NVivo, Qualtrics
Management	Multi-country project coordination, partner and stakeholder management, enumerator training, workshop facilitation, student and intern supervision
Communication	Academic writing, policy dissemination, teaching, editorial work

Languages

German, native speaker (C2) English, fluent (C1, bilingual schooling) Dutch (B1) Spanish (A2)

Volunteering and Civil Service

2020–2021	Volunteer , Austrian Red Cross, Vienna. Co-developed Vienna’s COVID-19 testing strategy and managed daily operations of up to 1,200 tests per day.
2015–2016	Civil Servant , Austrian Red Cross, Graz. Emergency services, medical transports, and community health support.